Threads of Affection

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Threads of Affection

by Lunaeryi

Summary

Phainon has never been one for grand romantic gestures, but that doesn't stop him from trying. From disastrous gifts to poorly executed love letters, he fumbles his way through every attempt—each one met with Mydei's deadpan judgment.

Does he give up? No.

(Five times Phainon tries to be romantic and fails, and one time he succeeds.)

Notes

Sorry y'all, I meant to do stuck in a box for Valentines Day, but I overestimated my writing abilities as I had NO idea how to start it, so I was just gonna call it quits until I realized fuck no, come on, it's Valentine's Day and then sat down and started making an outline.

Then I got distracted by a cute Phaidei fic (Favorite Customer for anyone who's curious) and gushed on that for an hour or two before locking in and writing this.

So hope you guys like it!!!

See the end of the work for more notes

The crisp winter air swept across Ampherous as Mnestia's Embrace approached—a festival that filled the skies with lanterns and the streets with the scent of freshly bloomed flowers. It was a time for love to take center stage, celebrated by all those who shared bonds, whether romantic or platonic. Phainon had waited for this day all year long, but for him, it wasn't just about love—it was about *showing* Mydei how much he meant to him. And knowing Phainon's luck with these things, it was also a time for things to go spectacularly wrong.

Phainon wasn't usually clumsy—at least, not in the way he was with Mydei. In any other situation, he had his wits about him, his charm in full effect. But with Mydei, he'd slip up. He'd become a little more awkward than usual, a little more nervous. He couldn't quite help it. There was something about the prideful and mocking look Mydei wore that made Phainon's heart race in a way that made *everything* harder.

And so, as the day of Mnestia's Embrace arrived, Phainon was once again determined to get it right. Mydei wasn't one for grand gestures, not the way some were, but Phainon couldn't help himself. He was going to show him. He was going to prove that, despite his usual antics, he could be serious when it came to this. But knowing Phainon's track record… maybe it would be easier just to embrace the disaster that would come out of this…

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1. The Flower Misstep

Phainon had been so *sure* about this one.

Flowers were a classic romantic gesture, easy, foolproof. He had seen them exchanged every year on Mnestia's Embrace—lovers gifting bouquets in soft pinks and deep reds, delicate blossoms tucked behind ears or pressed between pages like precious keepsakes. It was sentimental, sweet, *thoughtful*.

And Phainon could do *thoughtful*.

At least, that was the plan.

He had gone to the best flower vendor in town, a woman whose greenhouse was renowned for its rare and exotic blooms. A bouquet of simple roses had been right there—red, velvety, perfect. But then Phainon had spotted something in the back, hidden away like a secret treasure: a tangled collection of strange, wild-looking flowers, their long, curling petals shimmering faintly under the lantern light. Unlike the tame, fragile roses, these flowers had *presence*. They stood out. They were unique.

Just like Mydei, he had thought, with no small amount of pride in his own cleverness.

Sure, the vendor had hesitated when he asked about them. Sure, she had muttered something about them being "unusual" and "potentially a bad idea," but Phainon had waved her off. These flowers meant something. They weren't just ordinary—they were bold, striking, impossible to ignore. Just like the man he was giving them to.

So why, standing in front of Mydei now, did he suddenly feel like he had made a terrible mistake?

Mydei's expression was unreadable as he stared at the bouquet Phainon was holding out. His golden eyes flicked over the deep red petals, the curling tendrils, the faint shimmer of the leaves. One of the stems twitched slightly in the breeze.

"…What am I looking at?" Mydei finally asked, his voice flat.

Phainon cleared his throat, adjusting his grip on the bouquet like that might somehow make it look less… ominous. "Flowers. For you."

A pause. A long one.

Mydei exhaled sharply through his nose. "Phainon." His tone was so tired already. "These look *cursed*."

"They're rare!" Phainon insisted, shifting on his feet. "Symbolic! Unique! I thought you'd appreciate something *different*."

“Different?” Mydei repeated, still staring at the bouquet like it might try to bite him. Slowly, he plucked one of the flowers from the bundle and held it between two fingers, scrutinizing it. “…This thing smells like burnt sugar and bad decisions.”

Phainon felt a flicker of doubt. “…In a *good* way?”

Mydei gave him a look that could have withered crops. “Phainon. Be honest. Did you even check what these mean before buying them?”

Phainon opened his mouth, hesitated, then closed it again. “…No?”

A slow, deep sigh. Mydei ran a hand down his face like he was physically exhausted by Phainon’s existence. “Of course you didn’t.” He held up the flower like he was delivering a lesson. “These are ember lilies. They’re used to ward off bad luck.”

“See?” Phainon perked up. “That’s *kind* of romantic!”

“They’re also traditionally given to people you want to break up with,” Mydei deadpanned.

Phainon froze. “…Oh.”

“Oh.” Mydei echoed, smirking now, clearly enjoying this. “So either you’re completely incompetent, or you’re sending me a very interesting message right now.”

“Okay, in my defense,” Phainon began, “I thought they meant something cool and deep. Like, ‘our love burns bright like embers,’ or ‘you make my heart combust’—”

“You make my *heart combust*,” Mydei repeated, and now he was definitely laughing at him. “That’s what you were going for?”

“…Shut up,” Phainon muttered, face burning as he yanked the bouquet back.

Mydei just shook his head, still smirking. “Listen. Next time? Just get a normal bouquet. Or better yet—don’t *think* so hard about it.” He flicked the rejected flower back at Phainon. “I know that’s difficult for you.”

Phainon groaned, shoving the bouquet under his arm as Mydei turned to walk away. But despite the teasing, despite the mocking glint in his eyes, Phainon couldn’t help but notice the way Mydei’s smirk softened at the edges. The way he hadn’t actually *rejected* the flowers outright.

Phainon might have gotten it *horribly* wrong this time. But Mydei was still here. He was still amused, still indulging him, still his.

That had to count for something.

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2. The Serenade That Shouldn’t Have Happened

Phainon had been thinking about this for weeks.

Music was one of the most time-honored ways to express love—poets and musicians alike had sung their devotions for centuries. There was something undeniably romantic about a well-played ballad, something intimate about words spun into melody, something that could cut past even the thickest walls of pride and seriousness.

Which was *perfect*, because Mydei had *both* of those in spades.

And if Phainon could just *get this right*, Mydei would have no choice but to be completely, utterly swept off his feet.

The problem? Phainon wasn’t exactly a *musician*.

Oh, sure, he could carry a tune. He wasn’t completely hopeless. But the delicate, heart-stirring ballads he had envisioned in his head? Those required *actual skill*. And Phainon, despite his best efforts, was not blessed with that.

Still, he had committed. He had spent weeks secretly practicing with a borrowed lute, getting his fingers used to the strings, training his voice, *perfecting* the song he was going to play. He had chosen something classic, something timeless, something guaranteed to make even the most cold-hearted fool melt.

And then, naturally, everything went spectacularly wrong.

It started with the setting. He had planned to find Mydei somewhere *private*, somewhere he could create an intimate, romantic atmosphere. But the moment Phainon caught sight of him that evening—leaning casually against a market wall, the soft lantern glow catching the edges of his hair, his arms crossed in that way that made him look *infuriatingly* confident—Phainon lost his patience.

This was perfect.

No time like the present.

So before he could talk himself out of it, he slung his lute over his shoulder, strode forward, and, with all the flourish of a grand performer, began.

And that was when things *really* fell apart.

The first chord was… *wrong*. His fingers slipped on the strings, making a sound that was less *music* and more *dying animal.*

The second chord wasn't any better.

By the third, he could *feel* the way the entire marketplace had gone silent, heads slowly turning toward him.

But the real disaster was Mydei himself.

Phainon had been hoping for something like awe. Or admiration. Maybe even mild amusement.

What he *got* was Mydei staring at him, expression completely blank, as though Phainon had just started loudly declaring his taxes in the middle of

the street.

Phainon swallowed.

No turning back now.

He forged ahead, his fingers moving with *determination* across the lute strings, his voice carrying through the street in what should have been a smooth, poetic verse—

Except it wasn't.

The tune wobbled uncertainly. The lyrics, *which had sounded great in his head*, suddenly felt embarrassingly corny out loud. And worst of all? The *lute was slightly out of tune.*

The result was something that sounded less like a romantic ballad and more like a *threat*.

He reached the chorus—tried to put some emotion into it, *really* sell it—

And Mydei *broke*.

He didn't *laugh*, not exactly, but his lips parted like he was about to. His shoulders tensed as though he was *physically holding back*, his expression caught somewhere between secondhand embarrassment and complete amusement. His golden eyes were unreadable, but Phainon swore he could see the exact moment where Mydei made the conscious choice to *not* react.

Which was worse.

Because Phainon knew that look. It was the same look Mydei got when he was toying with him.

And sure enough, as soon as the song ended—after one final, off-key note that hung in the air like a bad omen—Mydei tilted his head, crossed his arms a little tighter, and blinked at him.

"Are you *trying* to kill me?" Mydei asked flatly.

Phainon, still gripping his lute, frowned. “What?”

“That.” Mydei gestured vaguely at the instrument. “*That* was not a song. That was a weapon.”

Phainon’s eye twitched. “It wasn’t *that* bad—”

Mydei exhaled sharply, eyes narrowing slightly, but his *lips twitched*, betraying him. “Phainon. Be honest. Did you practice this before or are you making me suffer in real-time?”

Phainon bristled. “I *practiced*!”

“…How much?”

Phainon hesitated. “Enough.”

“Define enough.”

Phainon hesitated again.

Mydei slowly, deliberately, arched a brow.

“…Look, music is *subjective*,” Phainon tried, attempting to recover. “It’s about the emotion, not just the sound—”

“Uh-huh.” Mydei hummed, completely unimpressed. “And what emotion was I supposed to feel? Fear?”

Phainon groaned, dragging a hand down his face. “*Romance*, Mydei. It was supposed to be *romantic*.”

There was a beat of silence. Then, slowly, Mydei leaned in, the smirk that had been threatening his face finally curling into place. “Romantic?” His voice was quiet, almost thoughtful.

Phainon swallowed. “…Yes?”

“Interesting.” Mydei nodded slowly, his gaze flicking between Phainon and the lute still clutched in his hands. Then, with the absolute *cruelty* of someone who *knew* exactly what he was doing, he murmured, “*Sing it again.*”

Phainon nearly *dropped* the lute.

“Absolutely *not*,” he blurted out.

Mydei smirked wider. “*Why not?* You were so confident a moment ago.”

“Because you’re *mocking me*,” Phainon grumbled, shoving the lute behind his back like that would somehow erase the past five minutes of embarrassment.

“Who, *me*?” Mydei asked innocently.

“Yes, *you*!”

Mydei let out a slow, amused exhale, tilting his head slightly. “Fine,” he said at last. “I’ll be merciful.”

Phainon sighed in relief—

Then Mydei smirked. “But only if you promise to never do that again.”

Phainon groaned loudly. “Fine.”

“Good.” Mydei turned on his heel, starting to walk away. But just before he disappeared, he tossed one last remark over his shoulder:

“You’re lucky you’re cute.”

Phainon nearly tripped over his own feet.

So, sure. Maybe the serenade had been an *absolute disaster*. Maybe he had publicly humiliated himself. Maybe he was never picking up a lute again.

But as he watched Mydei's figure disappear into the crowd—his shoulders still shaking slightly with *unspoken laughter*—Phainon couldn't quite bring himself to regret it.

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3. The Love Letter That Should Have Stayed Unwritten

Mnestia's temple was breathtaking this time of year.

Garlands of flowers hung from its marble pillars, glowing lanterns floating gently overhead, their soft light making the polished floors shimmer like water. The air was thick with the scent of incense and fresh petals, and everywhere, lovers walked hand in hand, whispering to each other beneath the towering statues of the Titan of Romance herself.

Phainon had never been the praying type, but even he had to admit—it was a damn good place for a grand romantic gesture.

Which was why he was here now, standing before Mnestia's altar, clutching a letter in slightly sweaty hands.

He had seen people do this before—write down their devotions, their affections, their most heartfelt confessions, and leave them as offerings in the hopes that Mnestia might bless their love in return. It was poetic. Sincere.

And surely, *surely*, Phainon couldn't mess up something as simple as *writing* a letter.

Except he *had*.

Horribly.

Because as he stood there, rereading the words he had poured onto the parchment in what had felt like a stroke of romantic genius, he realized—*this is the worst thing I've ever written in my life.*

It had started fine. A simple, heartfelt Mydei, at the top of the page. A promising beginning.

And then—disaster.

Because instead of writing something elegant, something refined, something that might actually stir emotion, Phainon had… well.

He had written this:

“Mydei,

You are—uh. Well. You know you’re impressive. I don’t need to tell you that. But if I did need to tell you, I would. (I am now. So I guess I do.) Anyway. I like you. I mean, obviously. But I like you in a way that makes me do stupid things, which I think you’ve noticed. (See: the last two incidents.)”

He groaned and dragged a hand down his face.

Why was he like this?

He had tried to be poetic. He really had. But for some reason, every time he put his feelings into words, they came out like this. Rambling. Awkward. Unpolished.

He glanced down at the next lines and winced.

“I was going to write you something poetic, something that compared you to the stars or whatever, but the truth is, stars aren’t actually that warm. You’re warm. And sometimes insufferable. But mostly warm.”

Phainon groaned louder.

He *shouldn’t have written this.*

Why had he thought this was a good idea?

Panic rose in his chest. He could not leave this here. Mnestia would take one look at this disaster and smite him on the spot. Or worse—someone

else might read it.

Mydei might read it.

And if Mydei saw this? He would *never* let Phainon live it down.

Absolutely not. No way. He had to get rid of it.

Unfortunately, he realized this *exactly* one second too late.

Because as he moved to shove the letter back into his pocket, a sharp gust of wind swept through the temple—

And ripped it right out of his hands.

Phainon swore loudly, watching in horror as the parchment fluttered through the air like a leaf caught in a storm, flipping and twisting—

And then, as if the gods themselves had a personal vendetta against him, it landed directly in **Mydei's hands.**

Silence.

Absolute, crushing silence.

Phainon's *soul* left his body.

Mydei, who had apparently just arrived at the temple, blinked down at the paper in his hands, his golden eyes scanning the words.

Phainon could see the moment he processed what he was reading, because his lips parted slightly, his brows lifted just a fraction—

Then, slowly, so *agonizingly slowly*, his expression twisted into a *smirk*.

Phainon, feeling the last shreds of his dignity slipping away, nearly lunged for the paper. "You don't have to read that—"

Mydei *sidestepped him effortlessly*, holding the letter just out of reach. “Oh, but why not?” he mused, his voice laced with *far too much enjoyment.* “It’s very… *insightful*.”

Phainon grit his teeth. “Mydei.”

“Hmm.” Mydei tapped the parchment thoughtfully against his palm. “So you think I’m *warm*, huh?”

Phainon groaned. “Give it back.”

“You compared me to the stars,” Mydei continued, clearly enjoying himself. “Then took it back. Very romantic.”

“I wasn’t *finished* writing it!” Phainon snapped.

“Oh? Then please, *continue*.” Mydei extended the paper toward him with exaggerated generosity. “Write more. Right now. I’d love to see how you end it.”

Phainon grabbed the letter, crumpling it in his fist. “I hate you.”

Mydei hummed, tapping a finger against his chin. “You like me in a way that makes you do *stupid things*, though. So really, whose fault is that?”

Phainon opened his mouth, then closed it.

Then *scowled*.

Mydei smirked wider, clearly pleased with himself. “Relax,” he said, and his voice was quieter now, the teasing less sharp. “I think it’s sweet.”

Phainon blinked. “You do?”

“Well,” Mydei mused, turning away, “I think it’s *painfully embarrassing*, first and foremost. But yes, *sweet*.”

Phainon let out a long breath, dragging a hand through his hair. “You’re insufferable.”

“And yet, you *like* me,” Mydei reminded him, throwing his own words back at him.

Phainon huffed. “Regretting it by the second.”

“Liar.” Mydei shot him a knowing glance, then—with an air of complete satisfaction—strolled out of the temple, as casual as you can be.

Phainon, still standing there, still holding his *very crumpled* disaster of a letter, exhaled heavily.

At least *this* attempt didn’t involve public humiliation.

But *gods*, Mydei was never going to let him live it down.

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4. The Dinner That Was Supposed to Be Perfect (But Definitely Wasn’t)

Phainon had thought this would be the one. The romantic dinner that would redeem him from all his awkwardness. He’d found the perfect recipe—warm, comforting, and rich in flavor. Simple, elegant.

He could do this. He was sure of it.

The first mistake came when he picked up the knife to chop vegetables—*without* properly sharpening it. The blade was duller than a rock, but Phainon, determined not to be discouraged, pushed on. His cuts were uneven, his hands fumbled, and one piece of carrot ricocheted off the counter and landed in the corner of the room. He groaned under his breath as he retrieved it.

Next, the lamb. Tender, flavorful, perfect.

But, of course, Phainon managed to drop it on the floor. His heart sank as he quickly wiped it off, trying not to think about the fact that this was already a *disaster*.

“Well, maybe it’s not too late to save this,” he muttered to himself.

The seasoning should have been easy. Salt, pepper, rosemary, garlic. But in his haste, he grabbed the sugar jar instead of salt. By the time he realized, the lamb was already coated in sugar—far too much for a savory dish.

“No, no, no,” he groaned, rubbing his temples. “I can fix this. More salt. Just more salt. It’ll balance out, right?”

But more salt only made things worse. The lamb was now sweet and salty—an unholy combination that Phainon couldn’t undo.

Frustrated, he moved on to the potatoes, which had to be easy. But in his distraction, he overboiled them and then added too much butter and cream. The result? A sad, mushy mess.

“Okay. Okay. It’s just a setback,” Phainon muttered. “I can still make this work.”

But then came the dessert—the pastries. Simple, elegant, just a little heat to warm them up. But Phainon forgot them in the oven. They came out blackened, burnt beyond recognition.

“Perfect,” he sighed, staring at the charred remains. “Perfect.”

He stood there in the kitchen, surrounded by the wreckage of what was supposed to be a romantic dinner. His shoulders slumped in defeat. It was clear now that there was no fixing this. He couldn’t even look at it anymore.

And just then, the knock came at the door.

Mydei.

Phainon froze.

He was supposed to impress Mydei, to show him that he could be romantic and capable. But now, all he had to offer was a disaster.

Maybe I should cancel this.

But it was too late. The door opened, and Mydei stepped inside, his eyes scanning the room. Phainon tried to straighten up, but it was no use—he knew Mydei would immediately see the catastrophe.

Mydei didn't say anything at first. He simply stood at the threshold, looking over the kitchen. His gaze flicked from the burnt lamb to the overboiled potatoes to the charred pastries.

Phainon opened his mouth to explain, but Mydei held up a hand to stop him. His expression was unreadable.

Phainon swallowed. *"I… I tried,"* he began, but the words felt weak, pointless. "I really thought I could make it perfect. I… I thought if I just—"

But Mydei interrupted again, his voice much softer now. "It's alright," he said quietly. He stepped into the kitchen, taking a quick look at the mess Phainon had created. "You really tried, huh?"

Phainon nodded, feeling the weight of his failure settle on his chest.

Mydei paused, the usual teasing glint in his eyes now replaced with something different. He reached for a fork, poking at the burnt lamb without much enthusiasm. For a moment, it seemed like he was going to say something—some comment, some sarcastic remark. Phainon braced himself for it.

But Mydei didn't speak. Instead, he took a bite.

Phainon's eyes widened. "Wait, you're actually eating it?"

Mydei chewed slowly, his face blank, but Phainon could see the slight tightness around his jaw. He swallowed before speaking. "It's… interesting," Mydei said, his voice quiet, almost reluctant. "Definitely not what I expected, but it's food."

Phainon's heart skipped a beat, unsure whether he was about to burst into laughter or sink into deeper embarrassment. "That's… that's the nicest thing you could say, huh?"

Mydei set down his fork and met Phainon's eyes, his expression almost unreadable. "Look," he said, his tone more serious than before. "It's clear you put in the effort. It's… not great, but I can appreciate that you tried."

Phainon felt a strange mix of relief and frustration. "I… really wanted it to be special."

"I know," Mydei replied. "And maybe it's not perfect, but I think it's the thought that counts here."

Phainon looked down at the table, feeling embarrassed again. "You didn't have to eat it, though. I thought you might—"

"I thought about it," Mydei interrupted, his voice calm, but still firm. "But I wasn't going to make you feel worse than you already do."

Phainon gave him a weak smile. "I'm sorry. I'll try harder next time."

"You better," Mydei replied, but his voice softened. "But, for what it's worth, it's… it's still a memory."

Phainon laughed softly, the tension easing just a little. "I guess so."

Mydei leaned back, eyeing the pastries with a skeptical expression. "I'll make you a deal. I'll suffer through this… if we order dinner from somewhere else."

Phainon couldn't help but grin. "Deal."

It wasn't the romantic evening he had imagined, but Mydei wasn't as disappointed as Phainon had expected. They sat together, finishing the "meal" with an understanding that was far more important than any perfect dinner.

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5. The Overly Ambitious "Perfect Day" Plan (That Phainon Completely Overwhelms Himself With)

Phainon's idea of a "perfect day" was ambitious—too ambitious. But he was determined to make it happen. He thought if he could pull off something that went beyond the usual routine, Mydei would finally appreciate his efforts.

He'd planned everything down to the last detail: a nice breakfast at the local café, a hike, a picnic, and then a sunset at the cliffs. It was a flawless plan—*on paper.*

But what Phainon hadn't anticipated was how quickly things would spiral out of control.

The day started early, and even though Phainon was running on little sleep, he was eager to start. He arrived early at the café, and by the time Mydei arrived, Phainon was already a little frazzled.

"You look like you're about to explode," Mydei said, eyeing Phainon with a raised eyebrow as he slid into the seat across from him.

"I'm fine," Phainon said, a little too quickly. "I've just got everything figured out. *Everything*." He said it like it was an accomplishment, though he could feel his nerves beginning to fray.

The food arrived late, the café was crowded, and Phainon was already tapping his foot impatiently by the time they finished breakfast. The clock was ticking, and they were already running behind schedule.

"Next stop, the hike," Phainon announced, his voice more strained than usual.

Mydei followed him, noting the way Phainon rushed ahead, clearly trying to stay on track. He didn't say anything right away—he just watched.

The hike, however, didn't go as planned. Phainon had overestimated both their stamina and the time they had. By the halfway point, he was already winded and his legs were sore from keeping up the pace.

“*Really* trying to do this all in one day?” Mydei asked, his tone neutral but with a hint of something that could’ve been amusement—or exasperation.

Phainon grinned awkwardly, though it barely covered his frustration. “We’re fine. Just… almost there. I’ll be fine.”

By the time they reached the picnic spot, Phainon’s energy was practically gone. And of course, the picnic basket was an absolute disaster. He’d forgotten utensils, the sandwiches were soggy, and the fruit was already starting to over-ripen.

Phainon set the basket down with a frustrated sigh, not even trying to mask his annoyance anymore. “I— I thought I had this under control.”

Mydei eyed the sad meal before glancing at Phainon. “You’ve got some serious delusions about what counts as ‘under control.’”

Phainon let out a tired laugh. “Yeah, no kidding.” He grabbed a sandwich and took a bite—almost like a last-ditch effort to salvage the day, but it didn’t go well.

They ate in uncomfortable silence, Phainon doing his best to ignore how everything was falling apart.

“Sunset,” he muttered, clearly trying to keep the plan going, though it was obvious he was about to collapse.

Mydei raised an eyebrow at him. “This *sunset* better be worth it.”

The drive was long, and by the time they reached the cliffs, Phainon was so exhausted that he nearly fell asleep behind the wheel. They got out of the car, and he could barely stand, groaning as he made his way to the top.

Mydei watched from a distance, leaning against a rock with his arms crossed. “You *look* like you’re ready to call it quits.”

Phainon just slumped, glancing at Mydei. “Honestly? I might be.”

Mydei's gaze softened a bit, but his tone didn't change much. "Yeah, I figured. You've been pushing yourself way too hard all day."

Phainon sighed, sinking down onto the ground. "I just wanted to do something nice… I thought I could make it perfect."

"Making it perfect for me doesn't change the fact that you're about to pass out," Mydei pointed out, not unkindly, though the edge in his voice suggested he wasn't going to indulge Phainon's self-pity.

Phainon sat in silence for a long moment, the weight of everything finally settling in. "I don't know what I was thinking. I've messed this up so bad."

Mydei gave him a sidelong glance. "You're dramatic. You're not *that* far off, though. It's just… been a long day." He let out a long sigh, stepping over to sit beside Phainon. "Look, if you're trying to make me think you're the best guy in the world… you don't need to do *this* much. You could've just asked me what I wanted to do."

Phainon gave him a tired look. "Yeah, I guess I should've done that."

Mydei raised an eyebrow, his tone still sarcastic but without the usual sharpness. "You think?"

Phainon let out a weak laugh, not bothering to hide his frustration anymore. "I've learned my lesson."

Mydei shrugged, giving Phainon a look that almost seemed like an acknowledgment of his effort. "Don't make it a habit, though. It's annoying."

Phainon groaned, leaning his head back against the rock. "You're really not making this feel any better."

Mydei glanced at him again, his lips twitching as if he might smile, but he kept it to himself. "You'll live."

As the sun dipped below the horizon, Phainon finally let go of the tension that had built up throughout the day. It hadn't been perfect, far from it. But

for some reason, with Mydei sitting next to him in silence, it felt *enough*.

Maybe *perfection* didn’t matter after all.

+1. The Unexpected Gesture

Phainon wasn’t trying to be romantic. He was simply walking through the market when the sight of a simple hairpin caught his attention. It wasn’t anything extravagant, but it had a certain quiet elegance about it—something that Mydei might appreciate, even if he wouldn’t admit it.

He bought it, still not quite sure what he was doing. Maybe it was the idea of seeing Mydei in it, or maybe it was just a thought that crossed his mind. Either way, he found himself returning to Mydei’s side later with the hairpin in hand.

“Here,” Phainon said casually, holding it out. “Thought it might suit you.”

Mydei glanced at the pin, his expression as neutral as ever, but the sharp look in his eyes remained. “And what exactly is this supposed to be?” His voice was gruff, but there was a flicker of something in his gaze that Phainon couldn’t quite place.

“It’s a gift, obviously,” Phainon said with a teasing smile. “Take it. You might look better with it in.”

Mydei gave him a long, slow look before taking the pin from his hand with a sharp, “You’re ridiculous,” but without an immediate protest. Phainon didn’t wait for permission—he gently lifted a lock of Mydei’s hair, working the pin into place without hesitation. His fingers brushed through Mydei’s hair with an ease that was at odds with the teasing glint in his eyes.

At first, Mydei remained still, his usual stoicism in place. But there was something in the way Phainon worked with his hair—careful, deliberate, as if the task mattered to him—that made Mydei pause. He was quiet, only watching Phainon out of the corner of his eye, not bothering to say anything as his hair was braided into soft, intricate patterns.

The touch was soft, and despite himself, Mydei could feel his heart thudding in his chest, something warm settling in his stomach. It wasn't anything overt—Phainon wasn't doing this to fluster him—but it was the way Phainon's fingers slid through his hair with care, how he kept his movements slow, focused.

When Phainon finished, he stepped back, his hands lingering in Mydei's hair for just a moment longer, as if assessing his work. Then, without thinking, he leaned forward, brushing his lips gently against Mydei's ear as he whispered, "You look beautiful."

Mydei froze, the words landing somewhere deep inside him, settling there. He didn't move, didn't speak for a moment, the quietness between them thick in the air.

It wasn't a grand confession. It wasn't even the type of sentiment Mydei was used to hearing from anyone. But for Phainon, it was enough. And for Mydei, it was far too much.

He finally broke the silence, his voice a little strained. "You really are ridiculous, you know that?"

But even as he said the words, he didn't pull away. In fact, he let Phainon's hands remain close for a little longer, his usual mask of indifference slipping, just slightly, as the tenderness of the moment settled between them.

Phainon might not have been trying to be romantic, but somewhere in the simplicity of his gesture, Mydei found himself at a loss for words—and, for the first time, he didn't mind.

End Notes

Andddd done. Again sorry abt not writing the Box thing but my brain is legit empty when I think of that, like the creativity got sucked out.

My main issue isn't the smut, but HOW they got trapped together without making it something generic like them on a mission but somehow stuck😭

Well whatever, I'll write it at some point but not today, happy Valentines Day everyone

(Oh Lord the 3.1 trailer though, I am NOT ready for itjdkdjdrjejdjdjdjjddkkd 80 pulls saved up Mydei come home😭)

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